

► **RASHMI DAGA**, Founder and CEO of FreshMenu, has a unique story. She worked in multiple industries when starting out—from TutorVista to Ola to Bluestone. She also tried bootstrapping a start-up before launching FreshMenu, which pioneered the cloud kitchen concept in India. It was among the first to bring a mobile-first food ordering platform where the food was cooked fresh in a neighbourhood kitchen. It tapped into the consumer insight that busy individuals love great food to come to their desk, and high-quality delivered meals were non-existent at the time. Over the past eight years, FreshMenu has continued to deliver on its promise, expanding to multiple kitchens and delivery locations, and has reached 5 million customers. Continued focus on execution, taste and menu innovation has helped it stand out in a tough market. “The journey of self-discovery, building leadership capability and learning to be resilient and patient in the toughest of circumstances have been my learnings during these years. Founders are eternal optimists and that’s what keeps me going every day,” says Daga.

After the initial funding of \$17 million, FreshMenu raised \$1.64 million in a round led by Lightspeed in 2019. The pandemic years have tested Daga and her team’s mettle to the hilt: “We have survived through the past two years in the toughest of circumstances. We have come out stronger with improved kitchen economics, profitability and a battle-hardened team. We will be growing to 100 kitchens in the next 18 months.”

She says the collective success of Indian start-ups in the past decade has inspired many more to decide to jump in and follow their dreams. Access to capital and

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talent pool has also been a huge enabler, which used to be a big difficulty back in 2010. She also believes in helping more women entrepreneurs navigate the journey and not repeat the mistakes of their predecessors. “There is no better time to be a start-up entrepreneur

in India than it is now,” says Daga. “Ten years ago, it was a risky career choice. Today, you have others that have come before you, who come together as a proactive network to help you figure it out.” **BT**

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